recover their sight.’[39] How many of these stupas had actually been constructed by Ashoka? Stone stupas were unlikely to have been built on his orders, Ashokan examples being mainly of brick. But evidently, in the seventh century these had come to be regarded by many Buddhist believers as being of Mauryan antiquity. Interestingly, Xuanzang drew attention to the ruined condition of several such shrines. North-west of Navadevakula, and at Prayaga, for instance, the stupas seem to have been in ruins. The traveller has a typical way of alluding to their state: they are described as possessing a reduced height, invariably around 100 ft, and the reduction is thought to be a consequence of their having sunk.[40]

Ashoka’s association with many of the places to which Xuanzang travelled persisted well into the medieval centuries. A good example of this is Sarnath. Here, in the twelfth century the queen of Govindachandra of Kanauj was inscribed into a record about a vihara that she had constructed at Sarnath. Kumaradevi was the name of this queen while the gift was recorded as being made to ‘Sri-Dharmachakra Jina’. More specifically, the copper plate grant says the renovations undertaken at her instance are meant to restore what existed in the time of Ashoka: ‘This Lord of the Turning of the Wheel was restored by her in accordance with the way in which he existed in the days of Dharmasoka, the ruler of men, and even more wonderfully, and this *vihara* for that *sthavira* was elaborately erected by her, and might he, placed there, stay there as long as the moon and sun (endure).’[41] Fourteen hundred years after Ashoka’s time a queen’s donation chooses to evoke what he built at Sarnath. This is a powerful reminder of the stamp of the emperor having survived, especially in connection with Buddhist sacred places.

We know from Ashoka’s own epigraph that he had a close association with Sarnath’s monastic community; later sources like Xuanzang’s account and Govindachandra’s inscription show that this association was never forgotten. There are, on the other hand, a few instances of places where